Who can challenge, correct and decide?

A close reading of Magnifica Humanitas and its formal governance findings

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1. The encyclical and this study

The document. Magnifica Humanitas is Pope Leo XIV's encyclical of 15 May 2026. An encyclical is a papal teaching letter addressed to a broad audience; this one addresses Catholics, other Christians and people of goodwill (§16). The official English PDF has 91 pages, including notes, and 245 numbered paragraphs. This report examines selected governance commitments within that document. It asks how an institution could demonstrate that its decision procedures supply the protections it promises. Paragraph numbers and page references below identify the official English edition, allowing readers to examine the source alongside our analysis.

The central concern. The encyclical places technological change within a Christian account of human dignity and the common good (§§1-16). Its opening contrasts Babel's self-aggrandizement with Nehemiah's cooperative rebuilding (§§7-10). For this study, that framework makes institutional arrangements a serious object of investigation: a person's ability to question a consequential decision depends on how responsibilities, channels and powers are connected. A protection can sound persuasive while leaving the affected person unable to reach anyone who can act. We therefore read the governance passages with a practical question in view: what would an institution have to show for its stated protection to operate? This approach develops implementation questions from the ethical commitments we select.

The wider argument. The five chapters move from the development of social doctrine and its foundations to technology and dominance, truth/work/freedom, and power/peace. The conclusion returns to Christian life and hope. This architecture matters to our reading. A small set of procedures cannot stand in for the encyclical's whole vision, yet a broad vision still invites precise examination of particular arrangements made in its name. We treat that relationship as the reason for a bounded study: select a connected group of commitments, explain our reading, and ask what their implementation entails. The resulting account should let a reader move between the ethical concern, the procedure proposed to address it, and the evidence that the procedure functions.

Why these passages. Our investigation selects §§97-111, on pages 33-38, within Chapter Three. This cluster provides the source locations for the responsibility, recourse, oversight, participation and design questions developed below. We chose it because these questions can be examined together within one decision process: who is assigned, who can challenge, who reviews, who can change a rule, and who implements a correction? The next page explains our reading before introducing the proof method. The later examples stay within three agreed domains: employment, public benefits and bounded high-stakes autonomy. The purpose is an inspectable connection between selected principles and working safeguards, with each additional procedural assumption stated.

Source: Leo XIV, Magnifica Humanitas, official English edition, 15 May 2026; introduction, chapter structure and selected §§97-111. Page numbers refer to this edition, accessed 2 November 2026. The full document is contextual background; the formal source boundary remains §§97-111.

2. A close reading of the selected passages

What we selected, how we read it, and why the questions belong together

From context to consequential decisions. Paragraphs 97-103, on pages 33-36, supply context about human direction, AI use and consequential decisions. Our selection treats the move toward decisions as the analytical hinge. Employment and public services give a decision an identifiable subject and consequence: someone receives an outcome and needs a route to question it. That makes it possible to examine responsibility at the level of a particular case. We use the surrounding observations to understand the setting, rather than treating every empirical description of AI as a permanent rule. This distinction keeps our inquiry focused on governance arrangements that can be specified and compared, while preserving the reason those arrangements matter to an affected person.

Appeal and accountable responsibility. On page 36, §104 addresses exclusion “without the possibility of appeal”; §105 requires that “responsibility must be clearly defined at every stage”. We read these commitments together as an invitation to examine a connected chain of responsibility. An appeal needs an accessible entry point; accountability needs an identifiable assignee; a correction needs relevant power. Whether a proposed arrangement actually joins those elements is our investigative question. The distinction is consequential: a case can pass through several named departments while responsibility for the disputed outcome remains difficult to locate. Our reading therefore directs attention to the same case, the assigned person and the scope of that person's power, rather than assuming that separate institutional provisions automatically connect.

Institutions and participation. Paragraphs 106-109, on pages 36-37, extend the discussion to institutional safeguards, participation and correction. Our analysis asks what evidence a claimed institutional protection would require. A reviewer needs a defined remit over the disputed decision; an intervention needs a route to an implementing action. Likewise, receiving a community recommendation, allowing it to influence an outcome and giving it a binding effect are different procedural arrangements. We examine those differences without treating any one mechanism as a complete definition of participation or subsidiarity. The selected requirements also leave wider questions outside our models, including the distribution of data and resources. Stating that boundary helps readers see precisely which institutional connections the study investigates.

Authority, development and our interpretation. On page 37, §110 challenges the assumption that “technical power automatically confers the right to govern”; §111, continuing onto page 38, addresses developers. These passages motivate two further questions for our study: what establishes an actor's mandate, and how is responsibility allocated across stages? We examine the evidence for each separately. Taken together, our reading of the selected cluster yields a research agenda about assignment, access, remit, authority, correction and implementation. Those are our explicit analytical categories. A proposed board, appeal desk or rule-revision process is a particular realization to be assessed, rather than wording supplied by the encyclical itself. This separation makes the forthcoming formal comparisons answerable to the source.

Source locations: §§97-103, pp. 33-36; §§104-107, p. 36; §108, pp. 36-37; §§109-110, p. 37; §111, pp. 37-38. Quotation marks identify exact short extracts; other source descriptions are attributed paraphrases. The procedural questions and interpretations are the study’s analysis.

3. Responsibility and recourse

What the formal comparisons establish about a particular decision

How the checking works. Lean is a program that checks logical proofs. We first distinguish a required safeguard from its actual provision, then describe hypothetical arrangements precisely. A failure example shows that specified provisions can coexist with a missing protection; a repaired example checks what additional evidence supplies it. The source commitment, our interpretation and the case assumptions remain separate. These examples are tools for examining proposed arrangements, not observations about actual agencies. The questions below come from the preceding close reading; the numerical scores, roles and procedures are explicit modeling choices.

Find the actual assignee. For §105 (p. 36), we test whether an identifiable institution and known staff establish answerability for the decision at issue. In the benefits example, a public contact handles inquiries while another officer is assigned to the denial. The contact can be identifiable while the actual assignee remains unidentified. A separate notice comparison publishes commitments and a correct score-47, cutoff-50 explanation; those facts still leave that gap. Naming the actual assignee repairs identification while the assignment and channels stay fixed. Lean also checks the sufficient connection from responsible institution through allocated decision to identifiable assignee. Correction power for that same assignee remains separate evidence. The practical requirement is case-specific: identify the person assigned to this decision and establish the relevant power.

Follow responsibility across stages. For §§103, 105 and 111 (pp. 35-38), our delegation comparison changes direct production to AI while retaining the officer's assignment and the existing safeguards. Lean checks that compliance with the tested policies is preserved under that specified change. Separately removing the assignment makes all three policies fail, even with appeal and correction capacity retained. The stage comparison distinguishes assignment for design from assignment for a later denial: design coverage alone leaves a downstream gap, while split developer/deployer assignments can cover both. Shared assignment is also compatible. These results make the handoff conditions visible; they establish neither automatic disappearance of duties after delegation nor sole liability for a particular actor.

Separate the available protections. For §§104-105 (p. 36), we examine person-accessible appeal separately from internal human review and correction capacity. Lean checks a case with human review but no accessible appeal. Both tested appeal readings reject exclusion without appeal. A broader reading additionally protects affected people before exclusion in high-impact cases. The employment comparisons show why wider appeal and harm-triggered correction capacity cannot substitute for each other: one applicant can appeal but has no correcting channel; another lacks pre-exclusion appeal while no harm triggers a correction duty. The different triggers are explicit. An institution applying our tests would therefore need evidence of access and correction capacity under the relevant conditions, rather than one undifferentiated claim of human review.

Apply the reviewed correction. For §§105-106 and 108 (pp. 36-37), the next comparison connects an appeal to an already-issued benefits denial. A corrected scoring rule yields a grant on reassessment, but the denial remains stored until an update is applied. The checked successful path requires open admission, an actual request, completed review, a working handoff, correction power and an update addressed to the implementing office. Missing the handoff, leaving the update unperformed or attempting it before review leaves the denial unchanged. The proof assumes the modeled order and checks are enforced. It changes the stored decision, not payment. The institutional question is therefore concrete: where does the reviewed finding go, and which performed action changes the record?

Evidence: technical paper §§2-5 (method, appeal, assignee, disclosure), §8 (stages) and §11 (applied correction); declaration references and assumptions accompany those sections.

4. Institutions, participation and design

Which powers exist, who holds them, and whether they reach the operative rule

Give oversight a decision-level remit. For §§106 and 108 (pp. 36-37), our oversight test asks whether the same independent reviewer covers the denial and has relevant intervention capacity. One board covers routine inquiries but not the disputed denial. A second arrangement adds denial coverage but lacks intervention power. A third supplies both; the other person-facing safeguards stay fixed. Lean checks these gaps and repairs. Independence is a stipulated case fact. The comparison tests capacity, while the previous page separately checks performed correction. In that composed workflow, the board has a usable intervention path precisely when appeal access, correction power and the handoff exist. A proposed oversight arrangement can thus be examined through remit, power and connection to implementation.

Specify what participation can cause. For §§108-109 (pp. 36-37), the participation model accepts, records and amends recommendations, and they influence outcomes when no institutional override is used. An override still permits either final outcome; a paired binding rule supplies operational final control. The distributed-pause comparison adds two separate external holds, belonging to an operator and an independent board. Initially, a recorded local request has no effect under any external setting. Enabling its input gives the community a pause while preserving both external powers. Requests and holds are assumed to reach and be honored by the evaluator. This establishes a specific local action, not award authority. It gives an affected group a precise question: what can its input actually cause?

Assess the rule being explained. For §§104 and 109 (pp. 36-37), we adopt a specific case policy: intake channel should not change entitlement for equally eligible applicants. Both applicants have verified score 60 and cutoff 50. The initial rule deducts 15 points for assisted intake, producing a denial, while online intake receives a grant. Both explanations truthfully describe the calculation. Lean checks failure of the adopted channel-equality and common-cutoff tests even though the existing responsibility and recourse checklists pass. Removing the penalty supplies both tests. The criterion is our stated case-policy assumption, not a complete account of justice. The result distinguishes correctly describing a calculation from justifying its chosen criterion.

Make the objection change the scorer. For §§104-105, 109 and 111 (pp. 36-38), we then connect a recorded objection to that same scoring family. A design reviewer without criteria-changing power leaves the penalty operative; a denial handler's case assignment also fails to authorize design revision. An assigned, empowered design reviewer can implement a proposal that passes the computed eligibility check. The returned rule actually feeds the scorer, so both applications then receive computed grants. Lean also proves that the corrected rule survives every finite modeled revision sequence, with fixed permissions and enforced validation over the two candidate rules. This supplies a working connection from objection to criteria change. It does not automatically reopen earlier denials; that requires the separate applied-appeal path.

Distinguish capability and mandate. For §110 (p. 37), we separate an operator's demonstrated outcome control from institutional recognition and decision remit. A capable operator can lack that scoped mandate; granting it preserves the technical capability. The more general result explicitly assumes that the authority interpretation requires a scoped mandate. Within that family, capability alone does not establish authority. The mandate remains institutional evidence, not a definition of complete moral legitimacy. A proposed governance arrangement must therefore identify both what an actor can do and the basis on which it is authorized to do it.

Evidence: companion technical paper §§6-10: oversight, participation/local pause, authority, adopted fairness and operative rule correction. The source motivates the questions; the particular procedures and enforcement assumptions are ours.

5. Timing, interpretation and practical use

What the results establish together, and how their evidence can be inspected

Ask when control becomes effective. For the preventive-control question motivated by §§97, 105-106 (pp. 33-36), the high-stakes case is a hypothetical application, not a source-specified mechanism. Two runs contain the same four events: stop request, delivery, execution and record correction. Delivery precedes execution in one and follows it in the other. Their final administrative flags agree, but only the timely run avoids physical loss. Lean proves that loss persists through every finite sequence of the available events. It also proves that a loss-free state with an already-delivered stop remains protected through every such continuation. These guarantees assume that delivered stopping is obeyed and the modeled events cannot reverse loss. The useful distinction is between a request, effective intervention and restoration of a physical outcome.

Show which conclusions remain stable. Across the tested requirements motivated by §§104-108 (pp. 36-37), we distinguish stable findings from additional policy choices. Missing actual-assignee identification fails all three safeguards policies. The oversight gaps persist even when all three pass. Broader pre-exclusion appeal and harm-triggered correction capacity are independent additions: either can be supplied while the other fails. A shared repaired benefits case meets eight tested combinations of responsibility, appeal and oversight fragments, with correction capacity retained and real triggering conditions present. That witness establishes compatibility; it does not make every conclusion invariant across eight complete readings of the encyclical. This comparison tells readers which extra requirement a conclusion needs and which displayed gaps survive the chosen policy changes.

Use the findings as a connected examination. The study's practical contribution is a sequence of evidence questions for any proposed arrangement applying the selected commitments. Identify the actual assignee and the decision covered by that assignment. Establish the affected person's route to challenge it, the reviewer's remit and the relevant correction power. Follow the finding through the handoff to the action that changes the stored decision. Where the objection concerns a governing criterion, identify the role authorized to revise the operative rule and the assessment applied to the revision. Where a dangerous action is pending, establish when intervention becomes effective. These questions connect the report's examples into one method of examination. They let an institution demonstrate a protection through its working relationships, while giving affected people concrete grounds for questioning a missing connection.

The earned outcome and evidence. The fixed study gives examined outcomes for ten target questions and six countermodel questions across the three agreed domains. Its contribution combines explicit dependencies, checked failures, repaired arrangements and conditional guarantees. We do not equate the theorem inventory with independent discoveries or claim that the original 10-15 independent-positive-result aspiration was met. The companion technical paper maps the results to declarations, assumptions and source records; the reproducible Lean files permit checking. The resulting artifact makes selected governance commitments precise enough to inspect while preserving the source, interpretation and implementation as distinguishable parts of the argument.

Formal evidence: technical paper §12, HighStakes.lean; §13, InterpretationRobustness.lean; §14, fixed-target/proof audit; §15, reproduction. Formal checkpoint: 0b938e373dbf538fe0853f6282e4d9502e67ea01, Lean 4.35.0. This public-report revision changes the explanation, not the technical paper or Lean proofs. Companion evidence: repository and technical paper supplied with the study.